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Herb Ellis — Part II

A second interview with guitarist Herb Ellis was conducted by Monk Rowe, Director of the Fillius Jazz Archive, on April 16, 2000 in Scottsdale, Arizona. Since his first interview in 1995, Mr. Ellis has relocated to the west coast and presently appears at special jazz events where he enjoys his role as a living jazz legend.

MR: I had a little tune here cued up.

[audio interlude]

HE: I couldn't do that now, no way. "Sweet Georgia Brown."

MR: This is 1978, a tune called "Shine."

HE: Oh yeah.

MR: That's great. Is it possible for you to describe what you think about when you're playing? When you're improvising?

HE: Oh that's a difficult question. I've never been asked that before.

MR: Well.

HE: I just try to shut everything out and just make the music the most important thing. I couldn't really tell you what I'm thinking about. I'm listening to the other players in the group, which makes you a better player. If you just shut out everybody and you let your ego run wild, you're not going to play as well. A lot of players do that.

MR: Ah. You let your ego run wild then it doesn't serve the music.

HE: No. You're playing with people, not against them.

MR: I see. If you're playing a tune that you're not all that familiar with, are you more likely to be thinking okay, what's the chord that's coming up.

HE: Oh sure. Right.

MR: Because it occurs to me sometimes at these jazz parties that, how can you possibly know every song.

HE: You can't know every song. And it's hard for me now because I don't play that much. Unfortunately I don't practice, rarely you know, two, three days before a gig I'll get the guitar out and play a little bit.

MR: So you kind of pick and choose your gigs these days?

HE: Um hum.

MR: Well you've been in the business since, let's see here, Soft Winds Trio.

HE: Yeah, it was before then though, I was with Jimmy Dorsey.

MR: Yeah, Jimmy Dorsey and Casa Loma Orchestra.

HE: Yeah.

MR: So that must have been the late 40s?

HE: Casa Loma was early 40s. Jimmy was ’45 through ’47.

MR: So you’ve been in the business over 50 years, well over 50 years.

HE: Oh my yes. I’m 78. I’ve been in the business, let’s see what time did I start, when I was in college — no when I left college to go with the band. So that would make me about 21, 20.

MR: Can you recall what your parents thought of you leaving college to go play music?

HE: Well they knew I loved music, and they were all for me.

MR: That’s great. When you got the chance to play with Oscar Peterson, that was what a five year stretch?

HE: Six years. Almost seven.

MR: What kind of challenge was that musically in that group?

HE: Oh my gosh it’s hard to describe. We had a lot of arrangements and they weren’t just charts that you’ve got a head, they were really complicated. And you had to remember them all, because we didn’t write it down. And Oscar made, he didn’t purposely make it — but he used to know about how much Ray and I could play, and he’d give us right up to the hilt.

MR: Is that right?

HE: Yeah.

MR: So there was a lot of like not written out, but ensemble things, in addition to the melodies you had to remember.

HE: Um hum.

MR: Wow. You guys were kind of practical jokers.

HE: They were, yeah.

MR: They were, not you huh?

HE: No I did a little bit, yeah.

MR: Can you recall some of the things.

HE: I can recall one of the things I did. We were playing, whatever place, and we had an intermission. So Oscar had been pulling jokes on Ray and I so I thought I’ll get back at him. So I took tape and taped some of the notes together, under the little lip of the notes, so you can’t see any tape.

MR: Under the key you mean?

HE: And he came out and of course he couldn’t play. But he took it good.

MR: Well he dished it out, didn’t he?

HE: Oh my gosh did he ever.

MR: I’m trying to remember, I read something about him tuning down Ray’s bass on occasion.

HE: Yeah. Well I don’t know if he — let me see — but anyway we’d have an intermission and we’d go back up to play. And he called a tune. Let’s say it was “Seven Come

Eleven," this was in A flat. So I started in A flat and I was way out of tune. Well he and Ray were playing in the key of A. So I tuned up to.

MR: Oh no. You re-tuned your whole guitar?

HE: Oh sure. And then I'd tune it back down again.

MR: While you're playing?

HE: Yeah.

MR: That's wild. What made Ella Fitzgerald such a great singer in your mind?

HE: She just had all the qualities. She had a melodic content, the sound, the phrasing. Everything. Probably the world's greatest singer to date.

MR: And what a scat singer, huh?

HE: Oh my gosh. Yeah. She's a spoiler. After you play with her and listen to her, other people sound mediocre.

MR: Was it ever hard for you to follow her singing with a solo of your own? You feel like she's already said it all.

HE: Well yeah, you're right. But on Jazz at the Philharmonic, she had a set and the quartet behind her, we didn't play any numbers. We'd just have some solos on some of her songs.

MR: What was Norman Granz like to work for?

HE: He was wonderful. Great businessman. And he had certain rules. I remember one time I didn't think I was getting enough money so I asked Norman for a raise. And he said, "You know better than that," he said, "I can't give you a raise in mid-tour." He said, "Before the next tour we'll negotiate."

MR: I see. Do you mind telling me what those kind of paychecks were like in those days?

HE: Well it was a long time ago. So five hundred dollars a week was big money then.

MR: Okay. That was, let's see when was that?

HE: '53 I went with him, '53.

MR: Yeah five hundred a week, that wasn't too bad, especially doing what you like.

HE: That's right.

MR: You've played with so many of the great, great people in jazz, and so many have played with you. Is there, in your career, what are the highlights for you? Have we already mentioned them?

HE: Hmmm. Highlights. I think certainly playing with Oscar and Ray was a highlight. And then playing with all the other people in Jazz at the Philharmonic. And what was a great reward for me and great confidence builder, almost all the ones when they'd make their own records they'd use me.

MR: That is a big compliment.

HE: Yes it really is.

MR: When did it occur to you to start doing these great duet records with other guitar players?

HE: Gosh. Well I first did them with Joe Pass. And I don't know how that came about. But we both played Donte's in Los Angeles you know, at different times.

MR: Played what?

HE: Donte's.

MR: Oh Donte's, yeah.

HE: It was the name of a club. So one time we decided to play together. And we packed the place. So after that when we played, we played together.

MR: I'm always curious about how two chordal instruments communicate when you're playing a tune, when you decide to go somewhere else with it.

HE: Well that's the secret — I mean it's not a secret — I mean it's just kind of you either have that or you don't have it. And Joe was the best soloist of course. And then the best accompanist that I've ever had. He knew just when to play something and just when to lay out. And hopefully I'm pretty good at that too.

MR: That idea of when to lay out is really important.

HE: Very important. Well see Joe listens to what everyone else is playing.

MR: Would you say that Charlie Christian was an influence for you?

HE: Absolutely. And Django Rinehardt to some degree, but Charlie was the biggest influence.

MR: How many opportunities did you have to see him?

HE: None.

MR: None? Never saw him live?

HE: No.

MR: He had such a short career, didn't he?

HE: Yeah. I think he died when he was 21.

MR: Did your upbringing, you're from Texas, right?

HE: Um hum.

MR: Did that have anything to do with the sound — was there a Texas swing thing going on back then that influenced your playing at all? Western swing?

HE: Well there may have been but you know we lived on a farm. So we didn't have any records you know, just a couple relative to that. So I just played and listened to the radio, and tried copy what I heard. I never had any lessons.

MR: No lessons at all?

HE: Um hum.

MR: What kind of things did you hear on the radio in those days? Was it the late 20s?

HE: Oh different things. A lot of country music. And I like certain things that are country. It's hard to describe. I just love the guitar. And my father was great. We had a farm and say

we'd be out picking cotton, so I'd tell him that I didn't feel well. And he'd say, "Okay you can go back to the house but you must practice the guitar."

MR: He was a smart man then.

HE: That's right.

MR: I had a question, I was wondering about the depression years for your family. Did it affect your lifestyle and the economy of the area you were in?

HE: It certainly did but I didn't notice it too much because I mean I was just, that's the way things were. And we always had great food, well we raised a lot of it ourselves. And I had very loving parents. I was very fortunate, and a sister and a brother.

MR: Did your parents stay on that farm for their whole life?

HE: Yes.

MR: And it was mostly a cotton farm was it?

HE: Well yeah, principally. And we raised corn to feed the animals you know, and onions we raised onions.

MR: What did you decide to go to school for?

HE: Gosh. I wanted to major in music. That's why I went. And so the last year of high school I got a mellophone, you know a French horn? And I learned to play it and I learned to read a little bit see? So then I could get into football games. And then I went to North Texas State and I thought I'd take the French horn up. But it's one of the most difficult instruments there are, to start that late. And you had to read in several clefs. So I bypassed that and changed to the bass.

MR: Oh you played bass also?

HE: Um hum.

MR: When did you finally switch to guitar?

HE: Well I played guitar all the time.

MR: Tell me a little bit about how the Soft Winds Trio came together.

HE: Well we were all three with Jimmy Dorsey. And I think the bassist Johnny Frigo, I think got us, that we could play in a certain room, I think it was in Detroit. So we loved Jimmy Dorsey's orchestra and Jimmy Dorsey. So we drew straws to see who had to tell him we were leaving. And Johnny Frigo, the bassist lost. He had to tell him. And Jimmy was very upset needless to say. And the guitar book, I had a lot of ensemble with the horns written. And some of it was pretty difficult. So Jimmy just negated that and got a rhythm guitarist.

MR: I see. It'd be hard to replace that kind of player.

HE: Yeah. At that time you didn't find anybody that could read that well.

MR: He was a pretty good saxophone player.

HE: He certainly was. You know who copied him and loved him was Charlie Parker.

MR: Yeah, right. He played some of those semi-classical things too pretty well. Didn't you do a reunion thing with The Soft Winds fellas a number of years back?

HE: Yeah. We were on a boat tour.

MR: Well is there anything in your career that you haven't done that you wish you could have?

HE: Not really. I've just been so fortunate and blessed with talent. And I've gotten to play with the best.

MR: Anybody that you would have liked to take and played a couple of gigs with? Charlie Parker perhaps?

HE: Charlie Parker of course. I got to play with Dizzy. Yeah I got to play with Charlie Parker one time. I was with a band, the Charlie Fisk band, and we had a few days off in Kansas City, and the tenor player knew this club that Charlie was sitting in, so we went out. And there he was playing. So we got up on the stand and the very first tune they played was "Cherokee," which is very difficult. So Charlie played. And he never played long. He never played many choruses, he didn't need to. So the guy next to me says, "You got it." I said, "No I ain't got it either." So I waited 'till they played some blues or rhythm, or something that I knew.

MR: Yeah, that "Cherokee" is one tough tune. You ever play that tune on these kind of parties?

HE: No.

MR: No one wants to embarrass themselves, right?

HE: That's right.

MR: You're taking just occasional gigs these days, like jazz parties?

HE: Right.

MR: Do you ever get together with Ray Brown and play anymore?

HE: No. He's the world's greatest bassist.

MR: Yeah?

HE: Absolutely.

MR: Is there a specific reason that he is?

HE: Yes. He knows the function of the instrument, and he just doesn't play a lot of notes which a lot of bass players do these days. He knows, he learns the songs and he knows almost every song written, and then he plays the basic notes. And he plays great solos. But playing the bass, accompanying people is the most important thing to him.

MR: That's good advice. Speaking of advice, if you had to give any parting words to up and coming guitar players in music these days, do you have any suggestions for them?

HE: Absolutely. I'd say when you're playing, improvising, sing along with what you play. That's very important. Otherwise you just play a bunch of junk and a bunch of scales you

know, which a lot of young people do I'm afraid. You know if you sing along then it will be music, because you're not going to sing anything stupid or dumb.

MR: You know, come to think of it, when I watch you play I see your mouth moving on occasion.

HE: Yeah. Well all the players I know that are good sing what they play. You can hear Oscar.

MR: I wonder how he keeps up with himself sometimes. Well I want to congratulate you on your marvelous and lengthy career. It's great to have you here this weekend, and I wish you all the best in the future. All right?

HE: Uh huh. My pleasure.